

CEMENT

CEMENTING THE FUTURE



58 |

▶ **INDIA'S INFRASTRUCTURE STORY** is reflected in the growth of several sectors. One of them is cement, demand for which cuts across sectors. With a total capacity of around 545 million tonnes per annum, cement is ready for the next phase. And the industry is hopeful that India's G20 presidency will open up those opportunities. "We can attract foreign investment and collaborate on knowledge transfer," says Mahendra Singhi, MD and CEO of Dalmia Cement Bharat. The long-term expectation is that re-



Reduced trade barriers due to G20 talks can expand the cement market

duced trade barriers can expand the market and help with climate change and sustainability. "The G20 economies are responsible for nearly 75 per cent of global emissions and their policy supports both sustainable practices and growth. Therefore, India can lead the transition... which can position [us] for long-term success," he explains.

Industry trackers too are sanguine. Deven Choksey, Promoter and MD of wealth management firm KRChoksey Group, says that cement can easily capitalise on the local market. "The demand [is] here because of infrastructure. That will sustain and, over time, we will only become more formidable as a cement producer," he says.

— Krishna Gopalan

AVIATION

TAKE-OFF TIME

▶ **IN AN INDUSTRY** that is still struggling elsewhere, India's aviation sector has emerged as the brightest spot. Domestic carriers ferried 88.19 million passengers in the January-July period against 66.95 million in 2022, per data from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation. This amounts to an impressive annual growth of 31.72 per cent and monthly growth of 24.67 per cent. And this was amply on display in June at the Paris Air Show. Of the total orders for narrow- and wide-body aircraft finalised there, the majority were by Indian carriers IndiGo (500), Air India (470) and Akasa Air (4).

"You look at the population we have, the economic growth, the geography, the diaspora; and the opportunity to support a much larger fleet is absolutely obvious," Campbell Wilson, CEO of Air India, tells *Business Today*. With India expected to become the world's third-largest economy by 2027, the aviation sector would benefit immensely. Vinay Malhotra, Head of Global Sales at India's largest carrier IndiGo, calls it an 'immense' yet 'untapped potential'. "Currently, the percentage of Indian consumers flying, both domestically and internationally, remains relatively low, signifying ample room for market development. The G20 presidency provides a crucial opportunity to leverage this potential, further accelerating the growth of the aviation sector in India."

With over 400,000 flyers, 3,000-plus flights and digital interfaces from identification to expedited security, visitors can't miss the transformation underway, says Satyendra Pandey, Managing Partner at aviation advisory AT-TV. The government is also working on developing Delhi as a global aviation hub. "The G20 often addresses financial regulations and international trade policies—that can indirectly affect [the aviation sector] by influencing factors such as foreign investment and market access," says Videh Kumar Jaipuriar, CEO of Delhi International Airport Ltd.

— Manish Pant

